

Extended Essay

“The effects of takeover by
L&T on MindTree’s HR
department”



Mindtree

Welcome to possible

Research Question: *“To what extent has the takeover by L&T merger affected the HR strategies of MindTree?”*

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Table of Contents:

Introduction – An insight on the current situation of MindTree.	Page 5
Methodology – Methods employed in order to write this essay.	Page 6
Main body – Profile of the company, background, implications of the merger, HR strategies and business tools.	Page 7
Conclusion and Recommendation	Page 26
Bibliography	Page 29

Introduction

A business organization is one that consists of many departments such as marketing, sales, finance, human resource, operations, purchasing and general management. Each consisting of different internal functions. According to *BusinessDictionary*, Human Resource is defined as “The division of a company that is focused on activities relating to employees. These activities normally include recruiting and hiring of new employees, orientation and training of current employees, employee benefits, and retention”. Every company possesses a human resource unit as a result of which it prospers due to the functions of the people present in the organization. Ideally, a strong human resource unit leads to a good corporate culture, high employee motivation leading to efficiency and high production.

Like any other business, MindTree: an Indian multinational information technology and outsourcing company, has a HR department; Which has recently undergone some changes due to the takeover by L&T, who put a new CEO and HR in place (Mohapatra & Mishra 2019). This has led to major changes in leadership and management of the whole company.

MindTree’s employees fear that their jobs are at risk due to increasing attrition rates in June (Mohapatra & Mishra, 2019) and the takeover may change their corporate culture and mantra of CLASS (Parthasarthy, 2019) which directly links to their corporate objectives. Therefore, this essay will analyse to what extent a major change in the HR policies of a business as a result of a takeover, impact its main corporate objectives carried forward by its employees. Hence the research question, ***“To what extent has the takeover by L&T merger affected the HR strategies of MindTree?”***.

Methodology

The investigation process for the essay comprised of acquiring both, primary and secondary sources of information. This was done in order to get a complete view of the situation faced by MindTree. Some of the secondary sources consisted of mainly news articles from LiveMint, EconomicTimes, Business Standard and SwarajyaMag, which helped in showing the current state of the firm, with respect to certain recent actions and its impacts. From the website: Moneycontrol, data about their financial performance through published accounts can also be seen. The use of annual reports from the company website has also highlighted all aspects of the company performance with respect to each department present. Primary sources such as interviews with the Vice President and Human Resource Manager were conducted to gain a vast understanding of the company. Furthermore, directly looking at the organizational structure, before and after the takeover; was also effective. Hence, the perspectives of the public, internal employees, numbers and company activities gives an omniscient view to gain sufficient knowledge in order to address the research question.

However, drawbacks were also concurrently present with each method used. For instance, the articles chosen may be biased due to twisted and incorrect information presented, as news outlets serve a main purpose to entertain their audience. The information provided may be exaggerated to appeal to the emotions of the audience. As a result, this may hinder the conclusion made. Moreover, some data may not be disclosed due to company policies, this may obstruct analysis as the confidential information may provide an entirely different perspective on the situation. Nonetheless, the drawbacks can be overcome by cross checking the information presented in the article with the interviews conducted and also providing a non-disclosure agreement to pursue further material to support the arguments and statements made throughout this essay.

Therefore, an analysis of the above materials provided a relevant knowledge about MindTree's current situation. Contextually, the data can be interpreted in order to see patterns and relationships and use it with regards to the business tools. The tools I have used such as SWOT Analysis and Ansoff Matrix. Furthermore, the use of this methodology will yield credible and reliant information for answering the research question with supported arguments and statements.

Background Knowledge

Founded in 1999, MindTree has been operating for 20 years. They are an Indian multinational information technology and outsourcing company headquartered in Bangalore, India and New Jersey, USA (Wikipedia "Mindtree"). Recently taken over by the conglomerate: Larsen & Toubro, the company employs approximately 20,204 employees and reached its target of earning \$1 billion in revenue in April of this year i.e. 2019. The company deals in digital solutions such as e-commerce, mobile applications, cloud computing, digital transformation, data analytics, enterprise application integration and enterprise resource planning, with more than 339 active clients and 43 offices in over 17 countries, as of 31 July 2018 (Wikipedia "Mindtree").

Ashok Soota, the now former chairman of the company addressed the employees as not employees but as 'Mindtree minds' (Parthasarthy "Mindtree's Third Coming: 'Under New Management'" 2019). The co-founder Subroto Bagchi was officially designated as 'Gardener' — tasked with nurturing the company's talent. They devised the corporate mantra of CLASS (Caring, Learning, Achieving, Sharing and Social Responsibility). As a result, by 2011, Mindtree had broken records to become the fastest Indian IT services company to bring in \$100 million in annual revenues.

The main objective of the company was growing the revenues by nurturing the primary moving force which is the people. Mindtree betted the growth through people function. The CEO made use of a very colourful analogy to make the same “Tadpoles in different ponds all look alike just like the technical people in our industry so the challenge for the companies is how you make your tadpoles glow in the dark”.

How is growth measured?

Number of Employees – Number of employees working in the organization.

Capital Employed – Amount of money invested by owners/ borrowed from lenders.

Value of Output – Amount of output produced over a given period.

Value of Sales – Value of sales revenue made over a given period.

Early Success and Growth Challenge

After reaching the first US\$100 Million in six years faster than any other IT Services Company to reach this target, Mindtree was challenged by global economic slowdown and intense competition from its top competitors Tech Mahindra, Wipro, Infosys, TCS, CTS and HCL. This poised a great challenge to keep the momentum on the growth path for Mindtree, the strategy adopted at this point of time was to sustain its achieved revenue rate as well embrace growth through organic and inorganic methods.

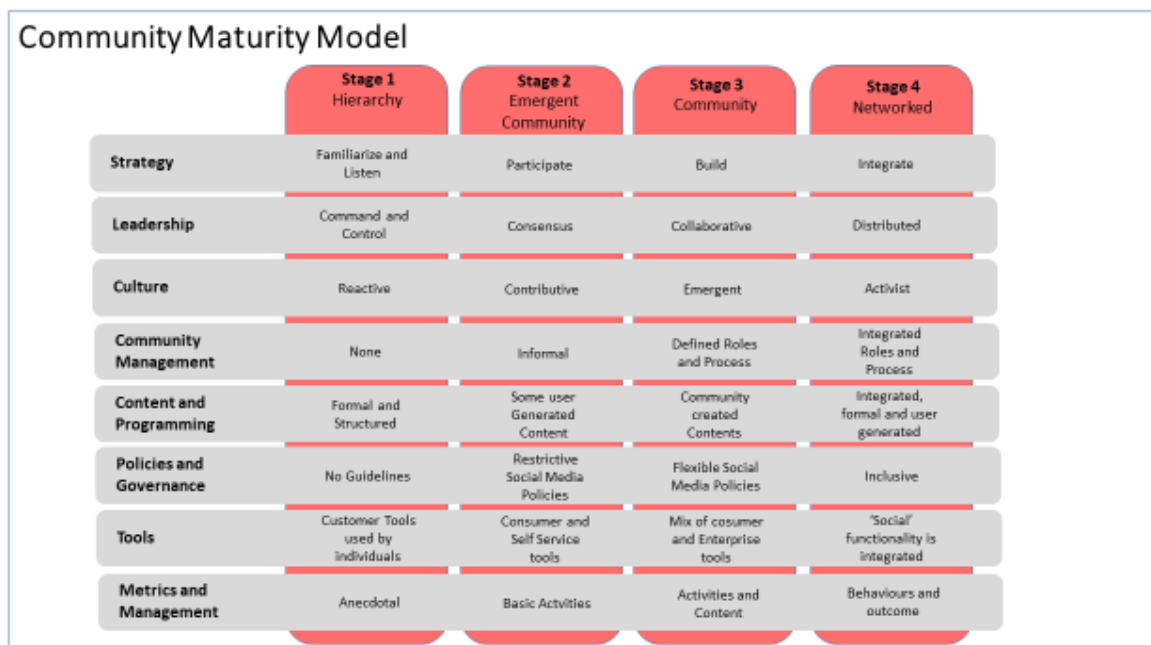
Inorganic Growth by Mindtree Acquisitions

This refers to business growth through mergers and acquisitions. The inorganic growth came through acquisitions which helped Mindtree to grow directly by around US\$ 100 Million of revenue per annum by 2019 of the US\$1B revenue earned. The employee strength also grew by around 1000 out of the 22,000 people force in 2019. The acquisitions made by Mindtree for this inorganic growth where the takeover of companies such as Bluefin

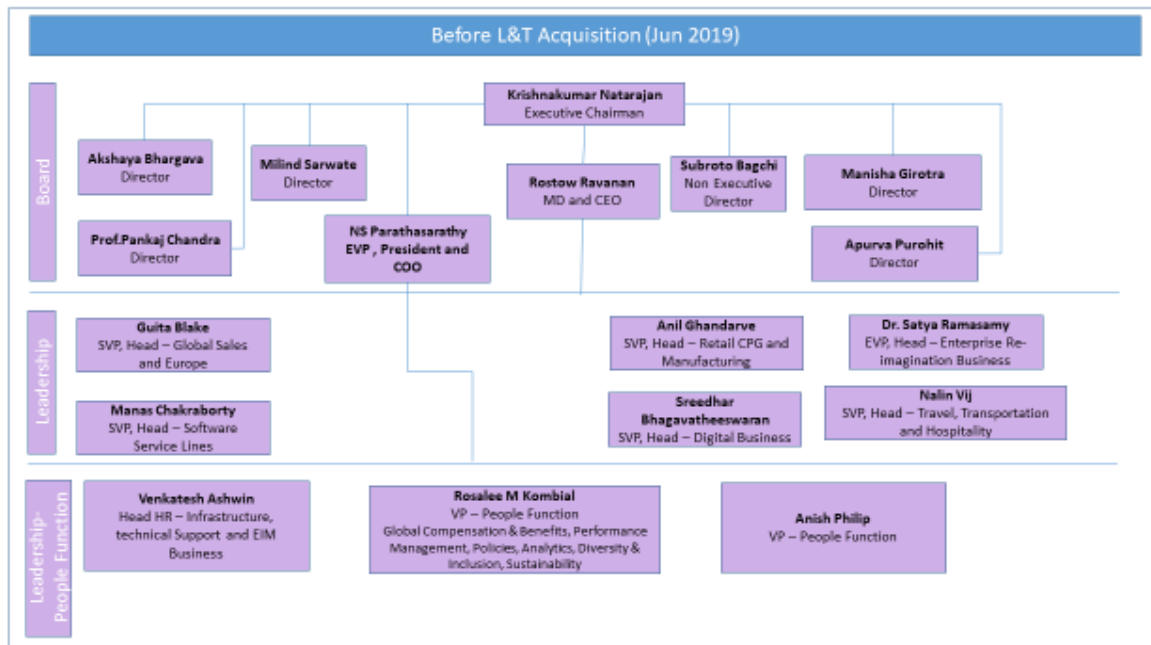
Solutions (US\$ 48M p.a of revenue), Magnet360 (US\$35M p.a revenue) Discoverture Solutions LLC Relational Solutions (US\$10M p.a revenue) Inc (US\$ 3M p.a. of revenue), Salesforce Consulting (US\$ 5M p.a. of revenue). These acquisitions also helped in bringing the best of people management and HR Practices across board, onto Mindtree's team. This also helped Mindtree to go jointly to the market for large deals especially in the area of SAP HANA solutions and Salesforce Consulting.

HR Practices for Organic Growth

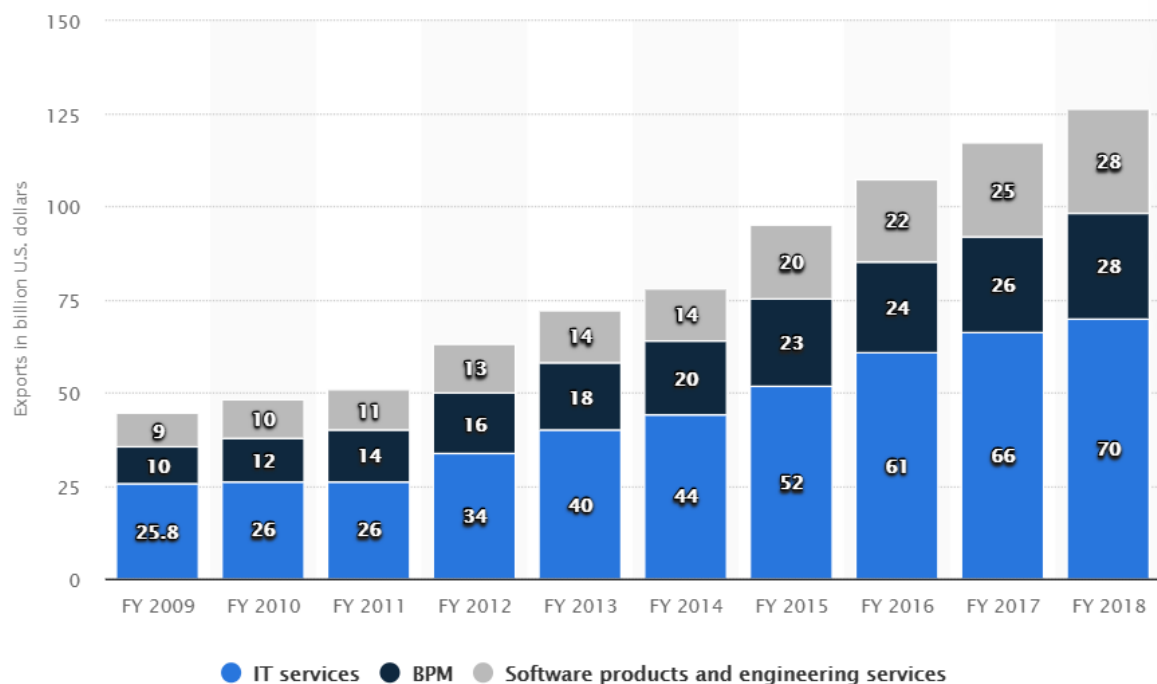
This refers to growth within the organization through the use of its own resources. While the inorganic growth helped to sustain growth during the challenging period the HR practices were most widely focussed for the higher level of growth with complete People-centric, Value Driven, Transparent and Participative approach. A mass cultural change happened when CLASS values were internalised, Socialization tactics were institutionalised and Knowledge Communities were built. The above dressed with Community Maturity Model made Mindtree to gallop towards the US\$1B mark in 2019, 20 years from its inception.



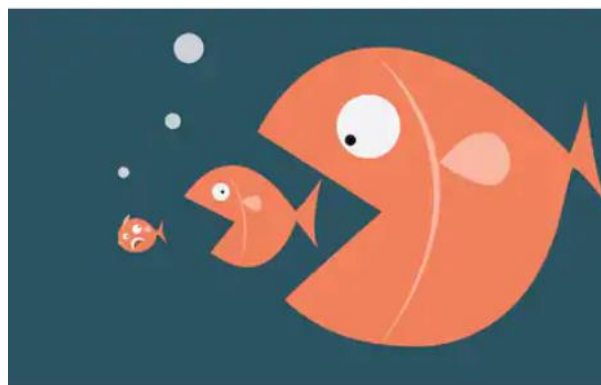
Till the acquisition of Mindtree by L&T that happened in July of 2019, the organisation Structure was a Matrix mostly with leaders who were long time employees in Mindtree.



Indian IT Industry Growth Trend and Influence on Mindtree



The IT industry in India is generally a fast-moving big revenue engine with a high YoY growth. The top companies in this industrial segment are typically agile, adaptive and aggressive with investment on people and technology. Highly successful companies have their footprints and customer base across various global locations. The biggest challenges on the growth of these IT companies are attrition of human resources, finding right talent, keeping pace with rapid technology advancements, investment into IT from other industries and Global Market Phenomena. Looking at the last 20-year history of the top Indian IT firms; they have been showing high percentage growth percentage despite market challenges, economic downturns and global phenomena. This they were able to be mostly done by virtue of investing on human resources and acquisition of smaller entities by the bigger ones. Because of this constant high growth trend, it has become a defacto standard for IT companies to project such growth rates and puts a pressure on these companies mainly to lean on large acquisitions and strong people policies to be successful.



Global IT Companies which grew large and fast had many acquisitions to their credit. Eg. Microsoft (237), IBM (168), Oracle (144), Accenture (157). Following pursuit are the Indian Top and leading IT companies Eg., TCS (16), Infosys (12), Wipro (22), Tech Mahindra (12 including major acquisition of Satyam Software), in the focus of this essay will revolve around Mindtree and L&T. Having their own individual acquisitions: Mindtree (11), L&T IT (10 from L&T Infotech (5) and L&T TS (5)). However, not all acquisitions have

been successful there were failed ones such as HP on Dell (Global), Sasken on Bothnia (India).

Well planned acquisition and merger strategy can offer a promising roadmap to success. Acquisitions can diversify revenue streams, broaden a company's capabilities and propel a business to dominance in critical sectors. In the IT industry, though it is possible to attract talents from competitors acquiring the companies can be of multitude benefits such as:

- Immediate revenue growth
- Advantage against competitors
- Best of both the worlds
- Cost reduction on operations
- Complement effect when pursuing large deals
- Increased cumulative experience of human resources

However even for the successful acquisitions the key challenges that needs to be taken care are mostly related to the people:

- Morale of employees from both entities
- Fear of losing job
- Compensation getting rationalised
- Cultural adaptation
- Fear of Losing role and responsibility value
- New Process and policies

Mindtree and its Acquisition by L&T

Mindtree has been a successful company in handling the acquisition of the 11 companies and had effectively kept itself and the acquired entity to propel growth. This mainly attributed to its strong HR Strategies, Policies and Process. Mindtree continued to use

the HR levers and acquisition strategy for the growth engine and the aspiration to top the IT leading pack of India. L&T IT companies (LTI and LTTS) had a mix of both being successful and some which did not meet the intended goal of acquisition. Majority of the acquired company employees left the organisation in due course and eventually L&T could not unfold the value of acquisition.

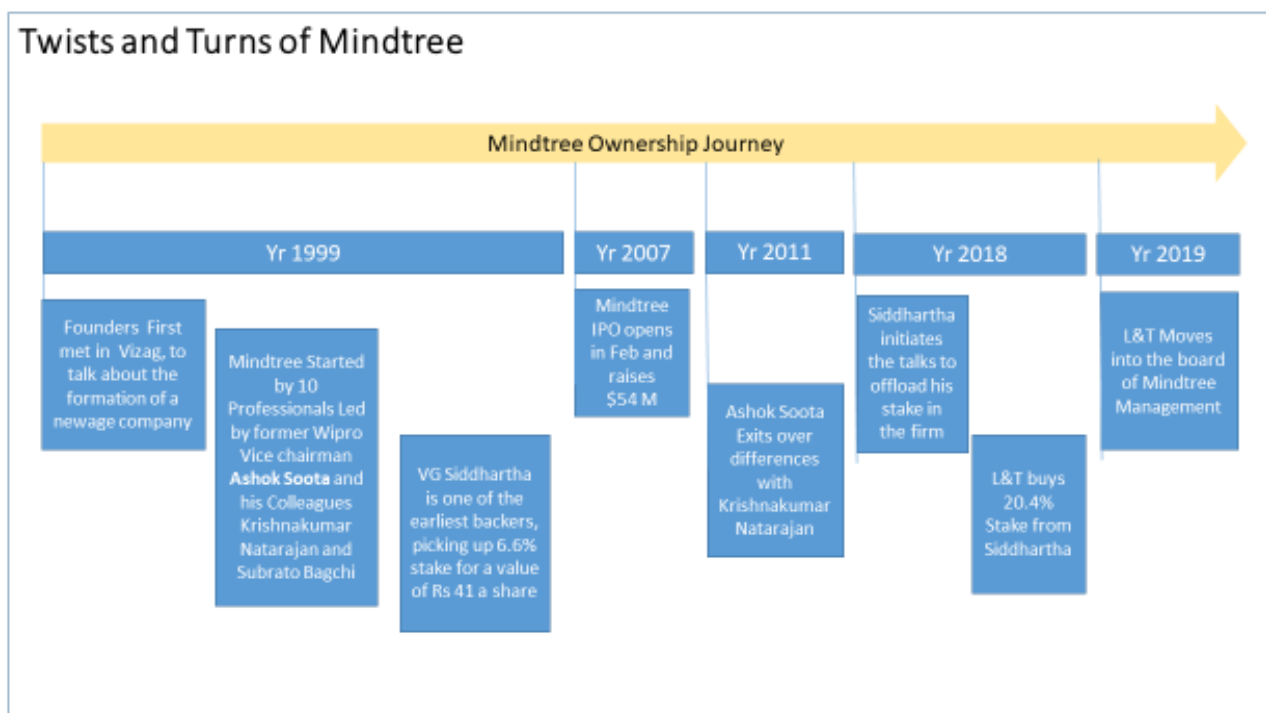
L&T Infotech from founded in 1996 has been for long aspiring to be a leader in the India IT Club on this journey they were scouting for large IT companies which can be taken over to fulfil the aspiration. In the year 2009 L&T Infotech missed a chance to Tech Mahindra in taking over Satyam Software (US\$2M p.a revenue) , this had hurt them badly as ***AM Naik Chairman L&T statement after losing bid stated, “We lost Satyam because we were too eager to buy it...I regret losing Satyam but life has to go on.”*** but continued to scout aggressively for the next opportunity which would fulfil their aspiration. Tech Mahindra moved up to the top 5 position of Indian IT companies club from 11th position by this acquisition.

While L&T Infotech were into small time acquisitions in reaching their US\$1B p.a revenue, door of a large size acquisition opportunity opens up for L&T in the year 2018 when Siddhartha of Café Coffee Day was initiating talks to offload his stake of 20.4% in Mindtree. This time L&T made no mistake to get it through. It had come as a shock to Mindtree Management and were terming this as a hostile takeover. (Subrato Bagchi’s twitter)



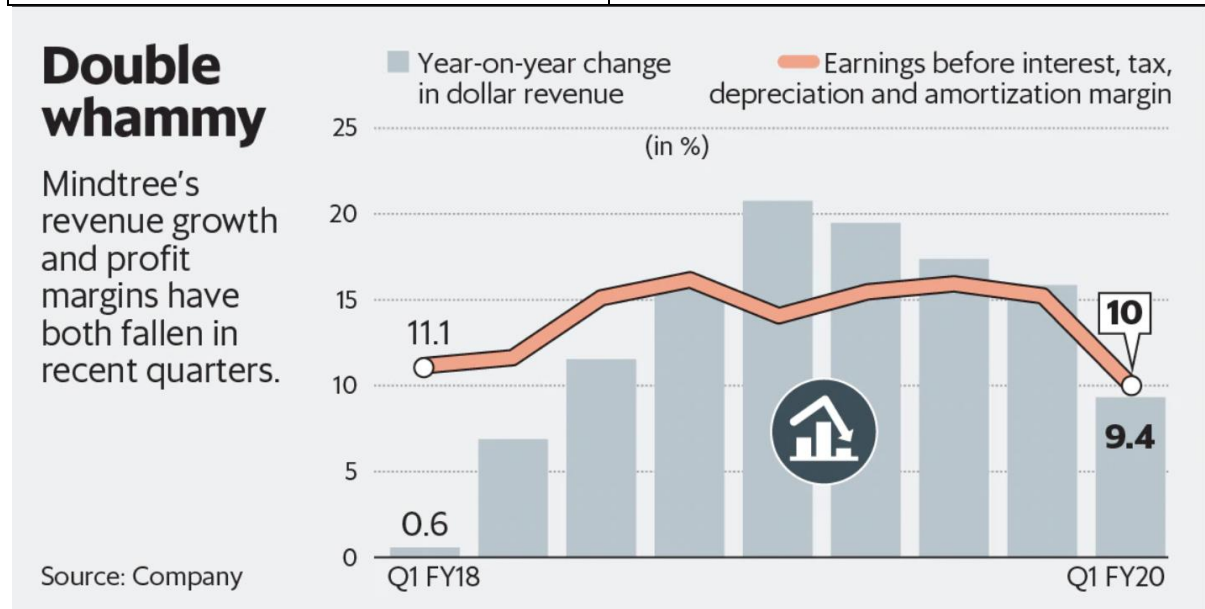
Not only did L&T increased its stake by buying CCD Siddhartha's 20.4% but went ahead and bought through open market offer 8.9% stake from Nalanda India Fund and Nalanda India Equity fund as well as from other investors taking the stake to 60.06% in Mindtree. The big fish ate the small fish which were eating smaller fishes.

Twists and Turns of Mindtree



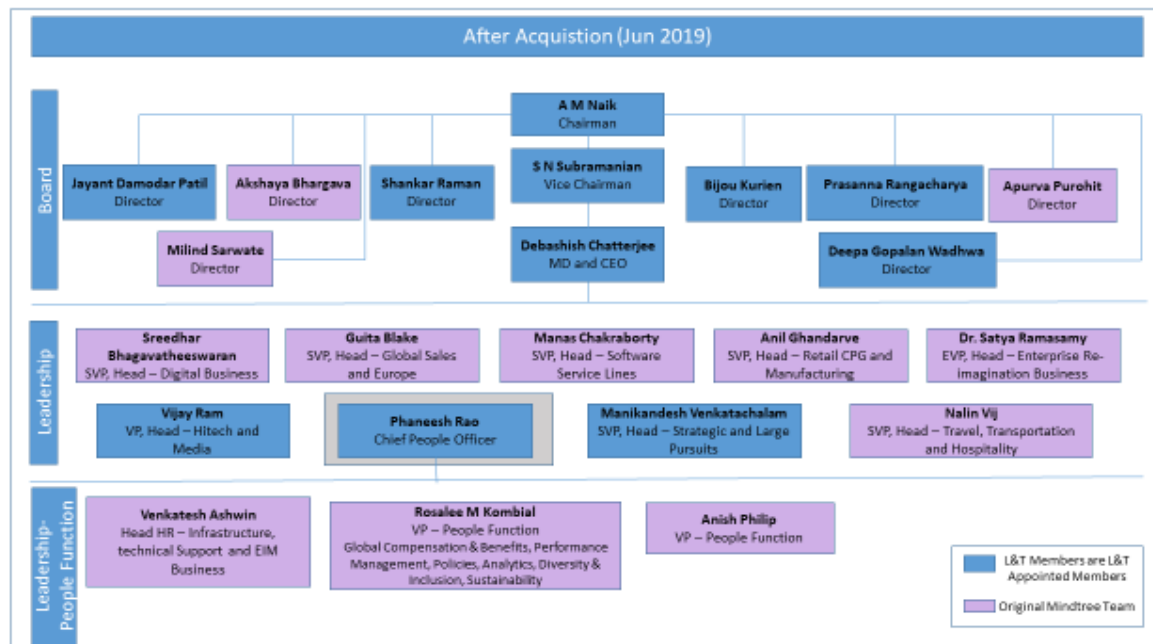
Mindtree after Acquisition by L&T (Implications of Takeover)

The Positives	The Negatives
New CEO devices 100-day plan	June quarter saw the weakest performance with a 41% dip in Profit.
Record deals worth \$324 million	Operating Margin fell 520 points.
New Headquarters in London	Attrition rates exceed 14.2%
	Revenue Decrease
	Revenue growth only 0.8%
	16% loss in stocks



Following the Takeover of Mindtree by L&T, L&T got in their members to the board and some of the board members of Mindtree saw an exit which led the attrition rates to cross 15%. Since L&T understood that Mindtree's strength lies in their people function there were no changes made to the working team and executives of the HR team, except the (Chief Human Resource Officer) CHRO was brought from L&T Tech services to head the Mindtree People function. Paneesh Rao comes with three decades of experience in HR across various fields of IT and BPO. He also carries with him lobal experience in managing HR across

multiple countries, such as Australia, Canada, France, Hungary, India, Japan, Philippines, Singapore, the United Kingdom and the United States of America.



Mr. A M Naik became the Chairman of Mindtree, Mr S N Subramanian became Vice Chairman and Mr Shankar Raman the Director of Mindtree. All from L&T Management. L&T also got in few more Board members into Mindtree. Krishnakumar Chairman, Parthasarathy Vice Chairman, Rostow Ramanan MD and CEO, Subroto Bagchi Director, the key members of the Board were resigned along with other Directors.

The board created additional positions at the key leadership levels to handle new business portfolios like hitech and media, strategic and large business deals.

The objectives of the acquisition and change of leadership is to meet the goals such as:

- Adding scale to its business in the IT Segment
- Escalating its stature and move up in the rank to sixth position amongst the Indian IT big wigs (US\$3B – *L&T Infotech* US\$ 1.3 B; *L&T Tech services* US\$ 0.6 B; US\$1B)

- Pursuing Large Deals with the added workforce and complement across the three IT arms of L&T (L&T Infotech, L&T Technology Services, Mindtree)
- Resourcing Fungibility across the three companies
- Optimising Operations and reduction of cost across the companies
- Taking best of the Project and HR Practices and use across.

Immediately after the takeover to allay the natural apprehension of Mindtree Employees on

- Losing Job
- Location Change
- Loss of Projects
- HR Policy changes
 - o Compensation and benefits
 - o Career Growth and Performance Management
 - o Employee Engagement

L&T Management S N Subramanian and Shankar Raman jointly addresses press meet mentioning that Mindtree would not be merged and it would continue to operate as a separate Entity. They expressed that they would

- Protect Mindtree's unique culture
- Setup a Council which would help in exchanging best practices
- Make it a win win for all.

Not in words, the newly appointed CEO Mr, Dehashis Chatterjee started engaging closely with clients and staff.

Communications in different forms were shared to the stakeholders and Employees of Mindtree as well as L&T.

- Through Media.
- Internal Circulars
- Email Messages
- Town hall meetings
- Stand up Calls
- In Person meetings with Key Stake holders
- Through Paneesh Rao (Chief People Officer) in different forums with employees across the globe
- Specific to mention about the Connect and interact Sessions with the CEO and the Vice Chairman. Transcript of the CEO on the call *“First and foremost, Mindtree will be operating as it is as of now and the future is a long-term which is certainly not known to us, so, from all practical purposes, Mindtree will continue to operate as an independent entity. If I can just add that wherever possible I would rather like to leverage the contacts and the connects that L&T can give me.”*

Mindtree by virtue of its robust HR policy and unique culture have had strong revenue growth and margins and have also bagged numerous accolades like

- 2019
 - Rising Star award
 - Zinnov Leader Award
- 2018
 - Golden Peacock award for Excellence in Corporate Governance
 - ICAI Award for Excellence report in financial reporting
 - Leader in Zinnov Zones for Product engineering Services
- 2017
 - Microsoft awards

- SAP Partner Award
- Salesforce Partner award
- 2016
 - Mindtree has been voted as one of the 50 Happiest Companies in America for 2016.
 - Mindtree has been placed among the top ten BEST Award Winners by the Association for Talent Development for its most innovative talent development initiatives.
 - Declared the Gold category award winner of the Learning Elite awards 2015 by the Chief Learning Officer Magazine, for its innovative learning and development practices.

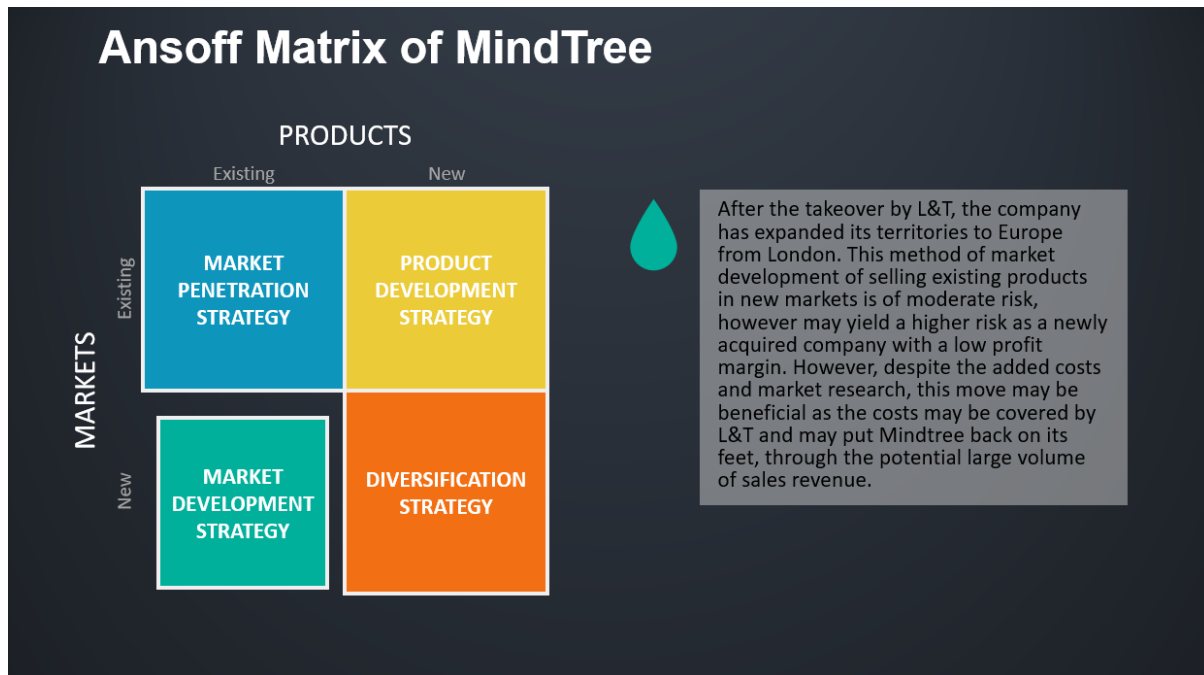
Business Tools

Adhering to the coursework, business tools can be used to further analyse the situation to better understand and construct a plausible solution for MindTree.

SWOT Analysis:



Ansoff Matrix:



Major HR Policy Areas of Mindtree

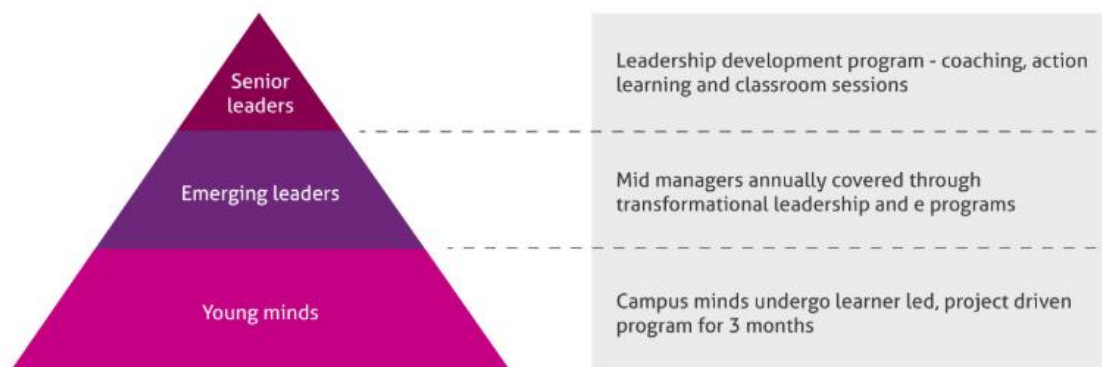
MindTree has its own HR motivation policies addressing Marslow's hierarchy of needs.



(Saul McLeod, 2018)

Career Development

Mindtree is a 2015 ASTD BEST Award Winner ranked 9th position world-wide. The ATD BEST Awards is the talent development industry's most rigorous and coveted recognition. The program recognizes organizations that demonstrate enterprise-wide success through employee learning and talent development. This is the third consecutive win for Mindtree at a global forum [2015, 2014, 2013].



Policies are existent to support learning and training at different bands and encouraged for role-based certifications.

Work-life Balance and Support

Leave Policy

Mindtree encourages employees to have a good work-life-balance through paid vacations, Country specific leave policies.

Work from Home Policy

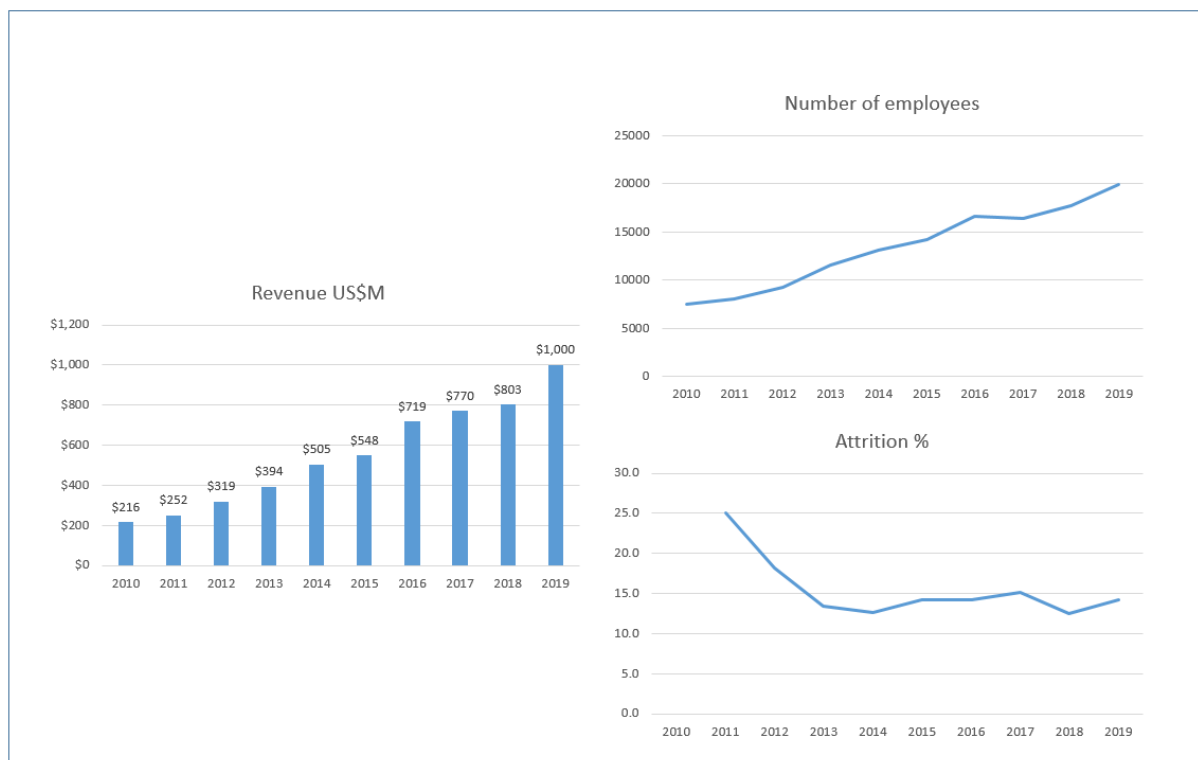
Allows work from home of employees.

Reward and Recognition

 Manager Bunker box	 Peer Bunker box	 Aspirational Awards	 Personal Awards
• Hat's off • Unstoppable • Master Mind • Eureka • A - Team	• Partnership • Trust & Respect • Accountability • Perseverance • Strategic Thinking • Influencing	• Annual Team Award • Chairman's Award • Outstanding Performer's Award • Pillar's Award	• Celebrating milestones (3, 6, 10, 15 Years)

Recruitment

Top Talents are attracted through Joining Bonus, Relocation allowances, Welcome kits and a seasoned induction Process for all levels. The revenue and employees' trend of Mindtree indicate that there has been a strong and steady growth on the resource count.



According to the discussion with the HR of Mindtree Attrition has been in control in the average range of 15% annually which is comparatively lower to the leaders in the IT Segment in India. The Last two Quarters have not had any big effect on Mindtree's performance. The Quarter after the acquisition though had an increased attrition rate

Key Financial Highlights

Quarter ended September 30, 2019

Revenue at \$271.0 million (growth of 2.6% q-o-q / 10.0% y-o-y)

Constant Currency growth of 3.2% q-o-q / 11.1% y-o-y

Net profit at \$19.2 million (growth of 43.5% q-o-q/ decline of 34.1% y-o-y)0

Other Highlights

Clients: 343 active clients as of September 30, 2019, \$5 million clients grew by 1, total 47

People: 21,267 Mindtree Minds as of September 30, 2019, Trailing 12 month's attrition is 16.5%.

L&T HR Policies

Looking at L&T IT Entities they have structured and wide spread HR Policies evolved through year from their PCMM certification model from year 2005.

We Care	We Acknowledge
- Celebrating Employee marriage - Unified Annual Health Check - Domiciliary Medical Insurance - Group term Life Insurance	- Rewards for IPR - Annual Awards for Performance - Sales Personnel Awards - Start of the Quarter award - Team Academy awards

- Meritorious Students of Employees - Reward for Academic Performance of Children of Employees - Medical Assistance Scheme for Life Threatening Diseases - Expectant Mothers for Safe and Comfortable travel - Recognise and reward excellence in Major events, Sports and Games at National/International/Inner States/inter University levels - Postretirement Medical benefits - Employees Provident fund - Reimbursement of maternity expenses in Complicated cases - Gratuity - Medical insurance for Hospitalisation - Mobile and internet Reimbursement - Company owned car Scheme	- People Champion award - Star of the month Award - Long service Award - rewards for Innovation - Reward for Conference and Journals - SPOT awards
Safe and Happy Travel	Org. Dev and Effectiveness
- Lunch reimbursement	- Reimburse Higher Education fees

- Inland travel - Car Mileage - Visa Sponsor	- Reimburse Certifications fees - Learning new Language - Being a Trainer recognition - Sponsor Management Education Programs - Sponsor PGEMP
Reward Management	Rejuvenate
- Compensation and Benefits - Performance Appraisal	- Fun and recreation Claim - Maternity leave - Paternity Leave - Flexible work Hours - Work from Home Option - Flexible Holiday choice - Part Time Work option - Leaves Donation to a needy colleague
Talent Attraction	
- Boomerang - Rehire Bonus - Buddy Referral - Joining Bonus	

A Way Forward

Having understood that L&T will operate Mindtree as a separate entity addresses the major issue of cultural difference of the two entities which have evolved through years successfully.

Based on the communications from the Chairman and the CEO it is understood that the Spinning wheels for success would be on

- Working on the best of the HR and Project Policies and Practices,
- Go to Market as a Single force,
- Improve Operational Efficiency,
- Provide space for people to work across the L&T IT Organisations.

These traits are expected to be enablers which might on the long run certainly expect to produce a positive result for all the entities as a whole. The revenue as whole for L&T as gone up, the individual entities may also move north bound at a higher rate on the revenue and the margins are expected to grow exponentially.

Conclusion

L&T and Mindtree have experience of multiple acquisitions and have learnt as well as acquired expertise in managing the acquisitions to be a success, L&T had some past acquisitions which have failed and have learned to persist. Having gone through the Mindtree's annual reports, looking through the revenue growth, margin maintenance and most importantly the HR Policies and Metrics (Attrition, Awards, Compensation, retention policy, recognition, work culture) Mindtree appears solid to go to a US\$2B in the coming years.

Similarly going through the reports, records, artefacts and other information source on the pedigree of L&T, It stands tall as and sturdy organisation which would strongly be able to back up and support the growth of Mindtree like how the other two entities of LTI and LTTS has grown under the aegis of L&T.

Though it is hard to say that there would be immediate tangible results that could be witnessed it is evident that in the long run there are going to be benefits especially on the revenue growth and margin improvements. There might some initial impact which might be off from the growth of revenue and holding the resources, but this is obvious that there would be an initial setback, which can be expected to be a temporary phenomenon.

Some challenges might that may come up could be in terms of the BigWigs of Indian IT trying to attract talent who are in an unstable mind set and living in a mirage of fear. Presently the world in general is experiencing a global economic slowdown which can also be a factor to test the gut of these integrated team.

L&T and Mindtree in addition to appreciating the cultural differences of each other through best policies can define in common for them in people management which could help them move up on the ranks against the Indian IT leaders. As separate entities they should continue to hunt few more large acquisitions like ITC Infotech, Sasken Technologies, Rolta India.

This conclusion is based on the information available through public domain, Annual report of shareholders, discussions with the Head of HR in Mindtree, discussion with Head of a Department in L&T. There were limitation with respect to the information that was made available by the Mindtree and L&T representatives as they were restricted to share all of the information in terms of HR data (change of leaders at working level, internal feedback from Mindtree employees, HR policy changes that are being done).

Some unanswered question that still loom would be

- Will policies be changed to cut down bench resources who are trained for future technologies by Mindtree?

- If the performance of Mindtree goes down how L&T could stand by their commitment of running Mindtree as a separate entity allowing them to recover by themselves?
- The bottom line of Mindtree is better than L&T entities, will the extra profits be reinvested into Mindtree people growth or it would be taken of?

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As an author of this essay I would like to thank the HR Department, especially Ms. Rosalee M Kombial : Vice President People Function, who had connected with the managers of different departments in Mindtree. Mr Hrishikesh Rao:Vice president L&T to answer the questions related to the essay research. Mr.Suresh Arumugam : Delivery Head, Smart Products and Services, L&T USA.

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